Outbound I ran in 2026, and the numbers behind it

Matthias Neumann · UnpauseAI · November 2026

UnpauseAI

Conference follow-up · treasury software · Jun to Sep 2026

127 reached · **40** in conversation (31%) · **20** with a meeting booked (16%)

Christmas re-engagement · UK events · Sep to Nov 2026

773 past customers · three emails each · **5** bounced (0.6%)

Corporate cold outreach · UK events · Jul to Nov 2026

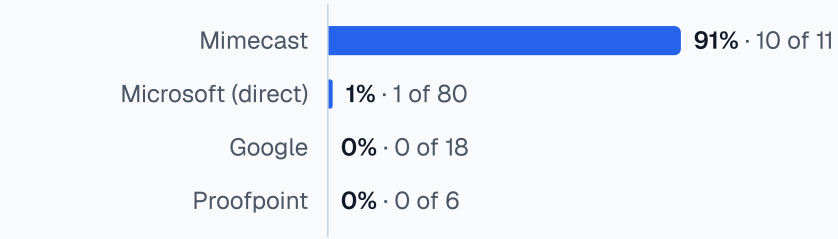
446 first emails over three waves · bounce rate **8.6%** to **0%**

1 Bounces an email verifier can't see

UK events company, corporate cold outreach, July to November 2026

128 first emails went out in July. Every address was NeverBounce "valid", and the batch bounced at 8.6%.

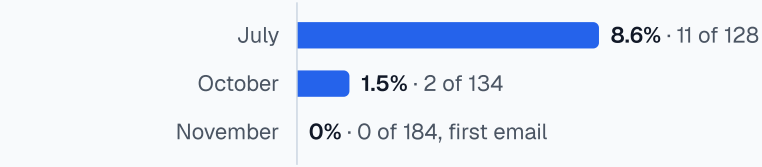
July bounce rate by the recipient's mail server



The other 13 sends went to smaller mail servers; none bounced.

Mimecast, a security gateway, refused the mail; a verifier only checks that the mailbox exists. The mail-server (MX) check became a standard load step after July.

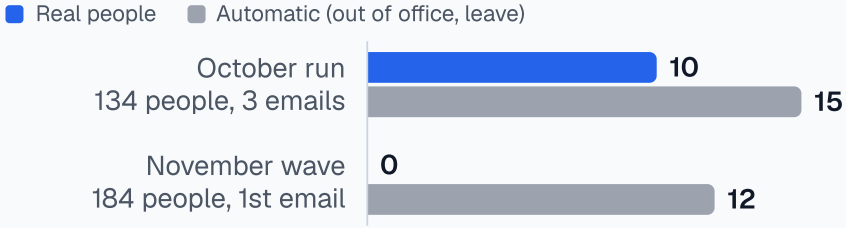
Bounce rate per wave



2 Most "replies" are machines

Same company, corporate cold outreach, October and November 2026

Replies per wave



Out-of-office and leave notices outnumbered human replies in both waves. A reply rate that counts them is measuring holiday season.

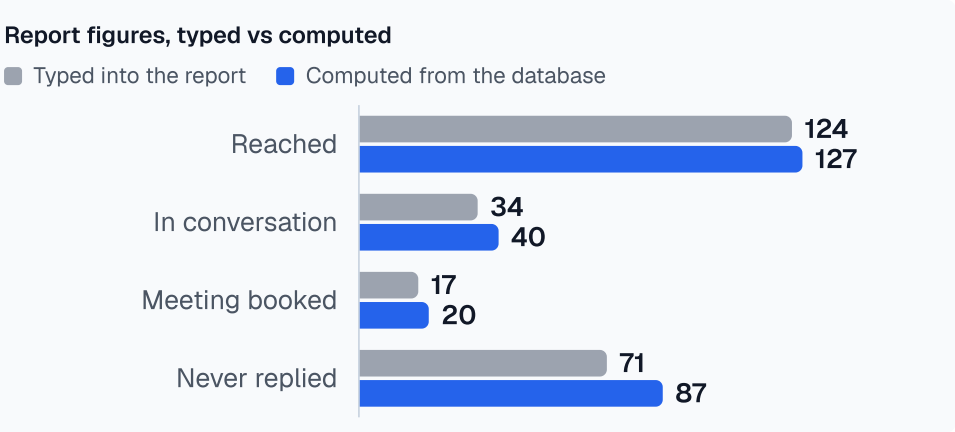
> **What I track instead:** real replies and booked meetings per stream, with automatic replies, bounces and unsubscribes counted on their own line.

Clients anonymized. Figures from the campaign records.

3 Report figures nobody computed

Treasury-software company, conference follow-up, September 2026

The client report's headline figures had been typed by hand. Against the live database:



The typed set did not even add up (34 + 71 is not 124). Two more gaps surfaced: of 62 people checked against both mailboxes, 12 had written to us (7 people, 5 out-of-office replies) and the log held 2; and 36 of the 62 next recipients would have been refused at send because two suppression lists disagreed.

> **Fix:** every figure is now computed from the event log when the report renders; a daily scan re-reads inbound mail from every folder; suppression is one check with "block" and "advise" classes.

4 Not mailing people who already booked

UK events company, Christmas re-engagement, September 2026



I joined the audience against the client's own bookings table (35 had already booked) and read 355 inbound messages to build the stop-list. Held means booked, sorted elsewhere, complained or in a live deal: kept off this wave but not blocked, so next season's re-engagement still reaches them.

A re-check just before launch found 28 new bookings in nine days, one of them in the send list. The lists are checked against new bookings every week.

5 Testing weeks of follow-up in minutes

German heat-pump installer, sales follow-up in n8n

26 rules react to each project's stage in their CRM. A test copy runs with a five-second day, so the second rule fires after about 2 minutes and archiving after about 3, instead of weeks. Their team runs it from one page, in German.

In every case the dashboard number was confident and wrong until it was checked against the source. That check is the first thing I'd build into an outbound agent.